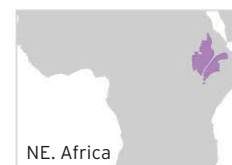


Ethiopian Montane Grasslands

A region of rare high-altitude grasslands, situated amid some of Africa's tallest mountains and a refuge for many endangered species



Northeastern Africa's montane grasslands are set mainly amid the eastern and western highlands of Ethiopia, with parts extending into the Eritrean highlands. Encompassing the Simien Mountains in the northwest, the Bale Mountains in the southeast, and part of the Great Rift Valley (see pp.184–87) between the two, this is a striking region, where jagged peaks surround high plateaus of grass and shrubland, as well as pockets of woodland, heather moorland, and alpine steppe. The most fertile montane grasslands occur at elevations of 5,900–10,000 ft (1,800–3,000 m). These attract not only a host of endemic reptiles, birds, and small

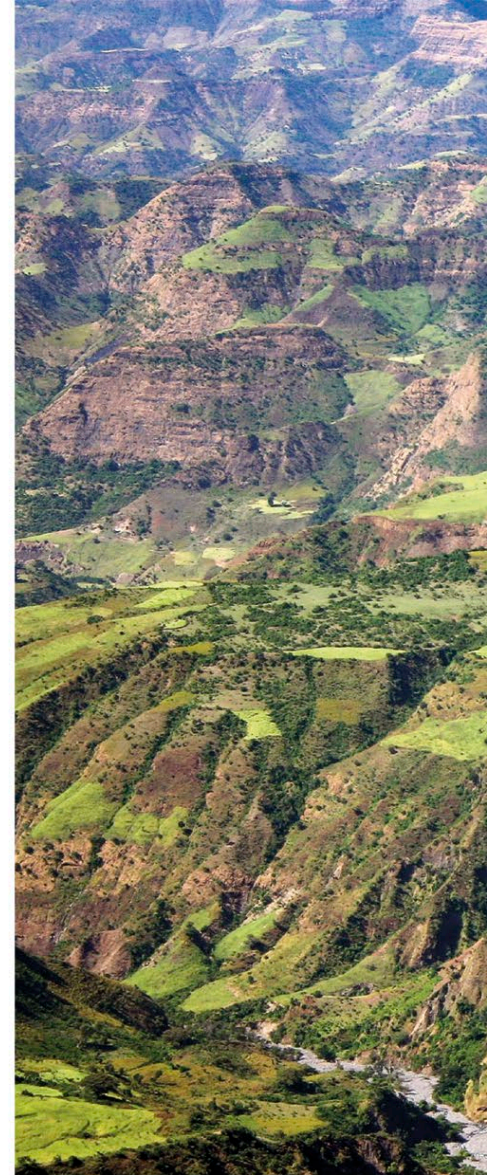


mammals, but also a high human population, whose agricultural activities and removal of the area's natural resources have resulted in a loss of about 97 percent of its original vegetation. Even so, these grasslands are a vital habitat for some of the continent's most endangered creatures, including the world's only population of Walia ibex and the Ethiopian wolf—Africa's sole wolf species.

◀ GRASS FORAGER

Geladas live almost exclusively on grasses from high-altitude meadows. They are also called bleeding-heart baboons due to their red chest patches.

84 small mammal species, many **endemic**, are found throughout the Ethiopian highlands

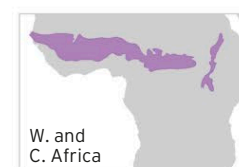


△ GREEN EXPANSE

South Sudan's Boma National Park turns a lush green after the annual rains, heralding the arrival of more than a million savanna grazing animals such as the tiang and white-eared kob—two antelope species that have converged here for centuries.

The Sudanian Savannas

A vast expanse of dry woodland and grassland, and a region of great botanical biodiversity



The band of mixed grasslands and trees known as the Sudanian Savannas stretches across western and central Africa from the Atlantic Ocean eastward to the Ethiopian highlands. To the north is the Sahel, the transition zone between the savannas and the Sahara Desert, while to the south lie the forests of Guinea and Congo.

West meets east

The ecoregion as a whole covers an estimated 354,000 square miles (917,600 square km) but divides geographically into two main sections, the West and East Sudanian savannas, which are separated by a much higher plateau in Cameroon. Large

tracts of hot, dry woodland comprising acacia and other deciduous trees characterize this landscape. There is an understory of shrubs, such as bushwillow, and grasses including the bamboolike Napier grass, with an average height of up to 11 ft (3.5 m), as well as shorter species such as thatching grass, which grows up to 31 in (80 cm). More animals are found in the western savanna, while the eastern section contains a much higher degree of botanical biodiversity, including around 1,000 species of endemic plants. The entire savanna ecoregion forms an important habitat for elephants, wild dogs, cheetahs, and lions, as well as migrating birds.